extremists to use East Berlin as an occasional base. Mielke never anticipated the gratuitous risks, he explained, but dealings with the terrorists 'simply swung out of his control'.5 Ten days after the bombing, US President Ronald Reagan ordered retaliatory strikes on Tripoli and Benghazi in Libya. (The action was widely seen as an attempt to kill Ghaddafi.)

Barely three weeks after the La Belle atrocity, the fallout was eclipsed by another explosion, this time at the Chernobyl nuclear reactor in Ukraine. As the world confronted the news that radioactive clouds were spreading across Europe, GDR TV kept shtum. Yet again, Western media became an important source of information for East Germans who found themselves helpless in watching the direction changes of the winds carrying radiation-rich clouds from the fallout area. In Ukraine, Russian responders were making up solutions as they went along as the machinery of government stagnated. After five days of torrid headlines in the West, GDR domestic radio launched a blistering attack on 'doom-mongers':

The accident in the Chernobyl nuclear power station and its tragic consequences for the people employed there is a fact. The readings of radiation measurements are another fact. According to the FRG Nuclear Research Centre in Karlsruhe, the radioactivity level poses no danger to health. Yet media in the FRG, of all countries, are having a field day. Their motives are obvious. Bild newspaper is once again serving up horror stories as ordered. Banner headlines are the order of the day: Atom Dust – Fresh Danger; Children's Playgrounds Contaminated; or Mothers, Shower Your Kids.

It conjures up apocalyptic visions against its better knowledge yet well knows what impact its enlightenment will have. Its main purpose is to project the Russians as the power of evil, a sinister menace looming on the horizon. Crop Losses in